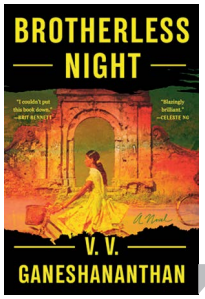
# WHEN LANKA BURNED

Set during the Sri Lankan conflict, **V.V. Ganeshananthan's** novel is a record of ordinary Tamils caught in war's brutality




**BROTHERLESS NIGHT**
*by V.V. Ganeshananthan*
PENGUIN
**₹699; 348 pages**

In her powerful novel *Brotherless Night*, V.V. Ganeshananthan tells the devastating story of the Sri Lankan Tamil conflict that burned for decades on the front pages of newspapers. Her narrator is Sashikala Kulenthiren, who is 16 as the story begins. She, her brothers and their friend K are thoughtful, mild, studious and just beginning to fall in love. She studies medicine as a calling, not as a road to prestige. But Sashikala's family are among the Tamil minority long baited and driven into a corner by the Sri Lankan government, and one by one, the young people are drawn into resistance movements.

"There is no single day on which a war begins," writes Sashi. "The conflict will collect around you gradually." She sees Sinhala families give up their neighbours to vigilantes. She witnesses cruelty on a biblical scale, from the Sri Lankan army at first, and then from the Tamil Tigers, who do not protect their community but only escalate the violence and exploit and kill Tamils whom they deem to be insufficiently committed to the cause. The Indian Peace Keeping Force, at first greeted with relief, becomes another agent of oppression.

*Brotherless Night* is also a story of how a close-knit family breaks apart under unendurable losses. And it is a love story, of the unspoken and yet intimate bond between Sashi and K.

**Brotherless Night** is a story of how a close-knit family breaks apart under unendurable losses

Step by conflicted step, young men and women became killers and suicide bombers. Ganeshananthan takes us as far as the spectacular end game of the conflict, in which tens of thousands, possibly hundreds of thousands, of civilians were trapped on a strip of land between the army and the Tigers and slaughtered. Most terrifying of all was that the world watched and did nothing. Sashi's story does not end with her removing bullets from guerrilla bodies and stitching up raped women. "To begin to believe it, we had to write it down," she says. The act of reporting atrocities and war crimes is itself considered treason, punishable by death. Throughout, she pleads directly with the reader—you have to understand, you must understand, I want you to understand. There are no monuments and historical markers of the final massacre at Mullivaikkal. No one counted the dead. But it did happen, they did die. And if women like Sashi have anything to say about it, they will count.

Even for those of us who watched from a safe distance, it is painful to go over this ground again, but Ganeshananthan's work is not just a harrowing documentary. She handles her story and her characters with control and clarity to create an authentic work of art. Somehow, threads of Tamil shimmer under her English, forming a narrative fabric of rare beauty. ■

**Latha Anantharaman**

# *A Wise Bird Saw It All*

Fabled personalities of 1940s–50s India meet in **Nilanjan P. Choudhury's** playfully fabulist satire

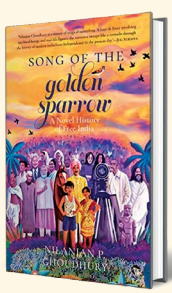
Stories that seek to take readers through a guided tour of history, be it Salman Rushdie's *Midnight's Children* (1984), Winston Groom's *Forrest Gump* (1986) or Vikram Seth's *A Suitable Boy* (1993), play with high stakes. Nilanjan P. Choudhury's *Song of the Golden Sparrow* doesn't take itself as seriously as these—it is a satire that begins with a slapstick, pun-heavy tonality and gets progressively sadder and more careworn.

The book's central conceit is endearing: a yaksha named Prem Chandra Guha is banished to newly-independent India, tasked with writing a thrilling history of the land. Prem (assuming the form of the common sparrow) ends up tailing Manhoos, a boy who lives in Netarhat (now in Jharkhand), and his friend Mary, a wise little Santhal girl.

There is much to enjoy in this comedic meet-the-legends lineup. Satyajit Ray derives some of his famous ideas from a conversation with Manhoos's benefactor, Raja Surya Pratap. Charu Majumdar turns up in the middle of a crucial story arc about the Naxalites. Fictionalised alter egos of famous Indians pop in, make in-jokes about their real-world lives, and pop out having delivered Aesop's Fables-like life lessons for Manhoos (who changes his name, significantly, to "Manu"). Choudhury has a lightness of touch even as he talks of weighty issues—the human costs of 'development', similarities between the British and 'brown sahib' babus, the apathy towards tribals.

However, as with many satires, the book feels pressured to maintain a number of puns and gags per chapter. This leads to purple prose: "A feeling of deja poo swept over me at the gloomy realisation, that shit, like history, repeats itself." Occasionally, Prem sounds more like a conservative uncle than the morally flexible narrator he mostly is. I'd have shaved some of these lines off, but these are small complaints about a book with a large heart, one that's firmly in the right place. ■

**Aditya Mani Jha**




**SONG OF THE GOLDEN SPARROW: A Novel History of Free India**
*By Nilanjan P. Choudhury*
SPEAKING TIGER
**₹499; 304** pages